

Art Therapy Guided Prompts

12 Expressive Art Activities for Therapeutic Use

These prompts can be used in session or assigned as homework. No artistic skill is required — the goal is expression, not perfection. Provide clients with paper, colored pencils, markers, or paint.

1. Draw Your Safe Place

Create an image of a place (real or imaginary) where you feel completely safe and at peace. Include as many sensory details as possible — colors, textures, objects.

Processing: What makes this place feel safe? How does your body feel when you imagine being there?

2. Inside/Outside Mask

Draw two faces: one showing how you present yourself to the world (outside), and one showing how you truly feel inside. Use colors, symbols, or words.

Processing: What differences do you notice? What would it feel like to show more of your inside self?

3. Emotion Color Wheel

Assign a color to each emotion you are feeling today. Fill a circle with those colors, using the amount of space that matches the intensity of each feeling.

Processing: Which emotion takes up the most space? Were any emotions surprising to see?

4. Body Map

Draw an outline of a body. Color in where you feel different emotions or sensations. Use a legend to show what each color represents.

Processing: Where does stress live in your body? Where do you feel calm or joy?

5. Before & After

On the left, draw how you felt when you started therapy. On the right, draw how you feel now (or how you hope to feel).

Processing: What has changed? What growth do you notice?

6. The Bridge Drawing

Draw a bridge. On one side, place where you are now. On the other side, where you want to be. What is on or under the bridge?

Processing: What obstacles are on the bridge? What resources are helping you cross?

Art Therapy Guided Prompts (cont.)

7. Anxiety Monster

Draw what your anxiety would look like if it were a creature. Give it a name. How big is it? What does it sound like?

Processing: Now that you can see it, does it feel less powerful? What would you say to it?

8. Gratitude Collage

Create a collage (drawn or cut from magazines) of things you are grateful for. Fill the entire page.

Processing: How did it feel to focus on positives? Which item surprised you the most?

9. Family Sculpture Drawing

Draw your family members as shapes or objects that represent their personality or your relationship with them. Arrange them to show closeness or distance.

Processing: What do the shapes and distances tell you? Would you change any positioning?

10. Tree of Life

Draw a tree. Roots = your background/heritage. Trunk = your strengths. Branches = your hopes and dreams. Leaves = important people. Fruits = your gifts/achievements.

Processing: Which part was easiest to fill? Which was hardest? What does that tell you?

11. Rain Drawing

Draw a person in the rain. Include whatever details feel right — umbrella, puddles, lightning, sun breaking through, shelter nearby.

Processing: How is the person coping with the rain? What resources (umbrella, shelter) did you include?

12. Mandala Creation

Starting from the center of a circle, create a mandala using repeating patterns, shapes, and colors. Work outward. Let the design emerge naturally.

Processing: How did the repetitive process feel? What themes emerged in your pattern choices?